WAR MACHINE



James Rhodes first appeared in Iron Man #118, in 1978. Another character brought in by David Michelinie and Bob Layton—this time with John Byrne—Rhodey was Tony Stark's pilot…but there was more to their friendship than that. It was soon revealed that, after Stark escaped from the cave where he had first built the Iron Man armor, he was rescued from his pursuers by Rhodey, who was repairing a downed helicopter nearby.

Later—when Tony succumbed to his alcoholism and had to give up being Iron Man—it was Rhodey who took over the role as the Armored Avenger. For many fans growing up in the early 1980s, James Rhodes was Iron Man. He temporarily took over for Tony again in 1992, but this time graduated to his new identity of War Machine—a souped-up, ultra-powerful version of the Iron Man armor—in Iron Man #284 by Len Kaminski and Kevin Hopgood.



Rhodey has always been far, far more than a sidekick to Tony, and the introduction of War Machine struck a chord with 1990s audiences. War Machine became—as James Rhodes had been in the Iron Man guise—a member of the West Coast branch of the super hero team the Avengers. Over the years, War Machine has starred in no fewer than four solo comic book series, with another on the way.

"We thought there was something really cool about having James Rhodes," says Jeremy Latcham. "In the comics, Tony becomes such an alcoholic that Rhodey grabs him, takes him to his aunt's house, sticks him in the attic and tells him that he's gonna go take care of business and puts on the suit and goes and does it. Rhodey is constantly dealing with Tony, and he's constantly cleaning up his mess. And it's something that probably gets really frustrating."





Their relationship has changed since the last movie, as Kevin Feige explains. "Tony doesn't make weapons anymore, so his role as liaison to Stark Industries for the U.S. military doesn't exist anymore. He's now a liaison to Hammer Industries—they're the ones that are taking over most of these contracts. There comes a point in this movie where the two of them have a major, major blowup—and it'll be interesting to see who the audience sides with, because we think they're going to side with both. When best friends start going at it, they both have a point, they both have a reason."

"Part of what makes the Marvel comic books cool is it really becomes about friends," Latcham sums up, "and it becomes about the people under the armors."

Art by Kevin Hopgood (left), Salvador Larroca (top right), Leonardo Manco (bottom right).